

```
# initrd /initrd-version.img
#boot=/dev/sda

default=1
timeout=10
splashimage=(hd0,0)/grub/splash.xpm.gz
hiddenmenu

title Fedora 9 (2.6.25-14.fc9.i686)
    root (hd0,0)
    kernel /vmlinuz-2.6.25-14.fc9.i686 ro root=UUID=xxxxxxxx-xxxx-xxxx-
xxxx-xxxxxxxxxxxxxxxx rhgb quiet
    initrd /initrd-2.6.25-14.fc9.i686.img

title OpenSUSE 11 @ /dev/sda7
    rootoverify (hd0,6)
    chainloader +1

title Mandriva 2009 @ /dev/sda8
    rootoverify (hd0,7)
    chainloader +1

title Linux Mint 5 (Elyssa) @ /dev/sda9
    rootoverify (hd0,8)
    chainloader +1
```

Briefly, the initial file was generated by Fedora 9 when I installed it as the first distro. Adding the subsequent entries for other distros is easy. We just chain-load and transfer control to the GRUB of the distro we want to boot. Each of the distros, in this case openSUSE, Mandriva and Mint, automatically create their own attractive GRUB menus at install time and we can leave them untouched. Remember to get the boot partitions right for each GRUB menu entry.

Sharing the home directory

To share your files seamlessly across your Linux installations, create your users in such a way that they have the same UID on each distribution -- each with their own dedicated group. For instance, you could have the uidgid series of 500:500, 501:501, and so on. This is the simplest scheme and should work well for a typical home-computing environment. You can also create users in such a way that certain users have access to certain distros and no access to others. You can thus restrict each user to just one distribution if you wish.

Typical usage scenarios

The default scheme with the common home directory across distros works fine, except for some side effects on the desktop. Since desktop (KDE, GNOME, Xfce,...) versions vary across distros, you might get widget load errors and some unintended desktop icons while hopping from one distro to another. This is because the 'dot' files for your desktop are common across all distros. There is

also the possibility of opening a file with a newer version of a software in one distro and rendering it unreadable by the same software with a different version number from another distro. As a solution, the following two approaches have worked for me, singly or in combination.

Rather than mount a common */home*, you can let the home directory stay with the respective distro so that your desktop stays there as well. Each distro then gets its own desktop and there are no unpleasant side effects. You can then mount your previously designated home partition separately under, say, */mnt/home*. If you like this approach, provision adequate space for the root ("/) partition of each distro (so that a 'small' */home* directory can stay there) and do not give any partition as a mount point for */home* while installing. This way the */home* directory gets created in the root partition of the distro, automatically.

The second approach is to follow some discipline. It helps to have a main distribution that you will use for mail review and other daily chores. You would rather not be messing around with mailboxes across distros. Having voted for your main distribution, you can then boot the distribution that specialises in the task at hand: perhaps media editing or gaming. With this approach, specific file and data types stay associated with a specific distribution and sanity can prevail all round.

Your mileage will vary depending on the distros you multi-boot. You should experiment to arrive at the template that works best for you and the work discipline that goes with it.

Pay day

Going by the examples in the references, you will not reach the limit on the number of distros that can be booted with a similar scheme any time soon. Once you have your PC set up with a flexible partition scheme, evaluating and comparing new distros becomes a walk in the park.

The grapevine has it that this leads to a condition called distromania. Symptoms include staring for long hours at installation progress bars and then rushing to boot a new distribution every couple of hours. Some people may need to be physically pulled away from their computers. Fortunately, in my case the condition was self-limiting—after trying out all distros that came with *LFY* in the past few months, I realised I had run out of CD blanks to burn more ISO images of lesser known distros. Then I quickly got down to writing this article before the next affliction could hit me. 

References

- www.justlinux.com/forum/showthread.php?t=144294
- www.justlinux.com/forum/showthread.php?t=147959

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